



defunct, while several new ones — Punjab FC (since 2020), Mumbai City FC (since 2022), and the AIFF-FIFA Academy — have come up or ramped up their operations across age-group tournaments.

JCT Mills had once honed India's record goalscorer Sunil Chhetri, while Lallianzuala Chhangte, one of India's best wingers at the moment, is a Shivajians' product.

"If they had continued, they could have helped produce a lot more players. To have an academy, it's not easy to sustain one," laments Renedy Singh, former India captain and a graduate of the TFA's second batch in 1996.

"Back then, TFA was the only major academy. We had foreign exposure trips every year, the best training, and there were a few coaches who used to come from abroad. For me, TFA gave us the lifeline; all thanks to Ranjan (Bhattacharya) sir, (Mohammed Habib) Habib sir and PK Banerjee sir, who was the director."

"There was a time when 10 out of the 11 players in India's U-19 team were from TFA, including me. We played against Japan, Qatar, China and Bangladesh," Renedy adds.

From 1992 until 2022, 273 cadets have graduated from TFA — 147 of them have played for India, with 24 leading the Blue Tigers. However, the number of national team players

from the academy has fallen drastically — from 17 in the first batch to just four in 2022.

The academies of ISL clubs, on the other hand, have failed to be the primary feeder for the senior team. In the last 12 months, 43 players have been called up for the national camp. Only 13 of them came through ISL clubs' academies.

Exposure trips have also played an important role. Minerva won the U-13 Gothia Cup in Sweden two years ago, while RFYC has had trips to Malaysia and Japan.

"I think the best example is when we went to the SuperMokh Cup in Malaysia. In 2022, we lost 0-8 and 0-7 in the U-14 category. Two years later, we won against two of the best academies in Malaysia in the same section," Robert Roelofsen, RFYC's Head of Youth Development, says.

"Playing abroad makes it easier to play in India rather than keep playing here. I let in some soft goals in Japan last year (SANIX Cup 2024). That gave me an idea about what I was doing wrong," Priyansh remembers.

"I worked on them, and when I came back to India, I confidently played over 35 matches for Mohun Bagan." Priyansh won the Golden Glove in the U-21 tournament this season.

A silver lining

India, however, is slowly learning to stitch its wounds — starting with

The past and the present: While some old academies — Lallianzuala Chhangte (top left) is a product of the now-defunct DSK Shivajians FC — shut, several new ones have come up. Priyansh Dubey (above) is a product of the Reliance Foundation Young Champs. AIFF MEDIA

the sculptors: the coaches.

Since 2022, the number of licensed coaches in India has increased by 86 per cent, with 500 of them currently under technical training to step up.

The AIFF-FIFA Academy now has an U-15 team that reached the semifinals of the AIFF U-17 Youth League this season.

"Evaluating the ones who are playing today, we must ask: Did we have a structured youth development system 10 years ago? If not, we must ensure today's youngsters don't face the same gap," Kalyan Chaubey, the president of AIFF, says.

India's tragedy does not lie in the fact that it can't produce world-class footballers. It lies in the obsession with quick results — the love for instant noodles over home-grown, self-cooked produce made with hard work. That needs to change.

It needs to accept the mess it is in, strive judiciously, and ride on patience to grow the beautiful game.